

Word family: **simple / simpler / simplest / simply / simplicity / simplify / simplification / simplistic**

Base word: simple

Comparative: simpler

Superlative: simplest

Adverb: simply

Related forms: simplicity, simplify, simplification, simplistic

Useful constructions/extensions: simple advice, simple explanation, simple task, simple design, simple life, simple majority, simple sentence, simple interest, simplify a process, simply because, simplistic view

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / related adverb, noun, and verb forms (相關副詞、名詞及動詞)

Your passage contains:

> “She listens first and then gives **simple but thoughtful advice**.”

Here, **simple** means:

clear, uncomplicated, and easy to understand, without unnecessary complexity.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **simple but thoughtful advice**

simple does not mean:

* childish;

* foolish;

* lacking value.

It means:

the advice is straightforward, clear, and not complicated, while still being meaningful and carefully considered.

The contrast with **thoughtful** is important:

> **simple**

> = easy to understand

but:

> **thoughtful**

> = carefully considered and meaningful

So the advice can be both:

> easy to understand

> and

> emotionally wise.

Meaning: Easy to understand because it is clear and uncomplicated.

繁體中文： **簡單清楚、容易理解、不複雜的；這裡指建議雖然簡單直接，但很有思考和分量**

中文翻譯：

> “She listens first and then gives simple but thoughtful advice.”

「她總是先聽，再給我一些**簡單但很有分量的建議**。」

So:

simple advice = 簡單、清楚、不複雜的建議

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. **simple = easy to understand (簡單易明的) — 簡單；清楚**

This is the exact core meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Not complicated; easy to understand.

Practice 1 — Original

> “She gives **simple but thoughtful advice**.”

「她給我一些**簡單但很有分量的建議**。」

Practice 2

> “The teacher gave a **simple explanation**.”

「老師作了一個**簡單易明的解釋**。」

Practice 3

> “Try to use **simple language**.”

「盡量使用**簡單易明的語言**。」

****simple = 內容或表達方式不複雜，因此容易理解****

2. ****simple explanation/language/instructions (簡單易明) — 清楚；不複雜****

Practice 4

> “The instructions are **simple**.”

「這些指示很**簡單易明**。」

Practice 5

> “She explained the idea in **simple terms**.”

「她用**簡單易明的方式**解釋這個概念。」

****simple + communication noun = 表達清晰、沒有不必要複雜內容****

3. ****simple = easy to do (容易做的) — 容易；不難****

A major separate sense.

****Meaning:**** Not difficult to perform or complete.

Practice 6

> “The task is quite **simple**.”

「這項任務很**簡單 / 容易完成**。」

Practice 7

> “It’s a **simple process**.”

「這是一個**容易操作的流程**。」

****simple = 執行某件事所需技巧、步驟或努力不多****

4. ****simple task/job (簡單工作) — 容易完成的****

Practice 8

> “It was a ****simple task****.”

「那是一項****簡單任務****。」

Practice 9

> “The repair should be fairly simple.”

「這次維修應該相當****容易****。」

****simple = 技術要求 / 難度較低，完成並不困難****

5. ****simple = basic / not advanced (基礎的) — 基本的；初級的****

A major educational/technical sense.

Practice 10

> “The course starts with ****simple concepts****.”

「課程由****基本概念****開始。」

Practice 11

> “Children learn simple maths first.”

「孩子先學****基礎數學****。」

****simple = 處於較基礎、初級、未複雜化的層次****

6. ****simple machine/system (結構簡單的) — 基本；不複雜****

Practice 12

> “This is a **simple machine**.”

「這是一個**結構簡單的機器**。」

Practice 13

> “The system uses a simple structure.”

「系統採用**簡單結構**。」

simple = 組成部分少、結構不複雜

7. **simple = plain / not decorated (樸素的) — 簡樸 ; 不花巧**

A major style sense.

Practice 14

> “She wore a **simple dress**.”

「她穿著一條**簡樸的裙子**。」

Practice 15

> “The room has a **simple design**.”

「房間採用**簡潔樸素的設計**。」

simple = 外觀、設計或裝飾不複雜、不華麗

8. **simple design/style (簡潔風格) — 簡約 ; 樸素**

Practice 16

> “I prefer a **simple design**.”

「我較喜歡**簡約設計**。」

Practice 17

> “The website has a simple layout.”

「網站的版面很**簡潔**。」

simple = 視覺元素較少、設計不繁複

9. **simple = modest / uncomplicated way of living (簡樸的生活) — 簡樸；樸實**

A common lifestyle sense.

Practice 18

> “They live a **simple life**.”

「他們過著**簡樸的生活**。」

Practice 19

> “She prefers simple pleasures.”

「她喜歡**簡單樸實的樂趣**。」

simple = 生活方式不奢華、不複雜，需求較少

10. **simple pleasures (簡單的小確幸 / 樸實樂趣) — 簡單樂趣**

Practice 20

> “Tea with family is one of life’s **simple pleasures**.”

「和家人喝茶是生活中的一種**簡單樂趣**。」

Practice 21

> “She enjoys the simple pleasures of daily life.”

「她享受日常生活中的**樸實樂趣**。」

simple pleasures = 不昂貴、不複雜但能帶來真實愉快的小事

11. **simple = straightforward / uncomplicated situation (單純的) — 單純；不複雜**

Practice 22

> “The situation is not as **simple** as it looks.”

「情況不像看起來那麼**單純 / 簡單**。」

Practice 23

> “There is no simple answer.”

「沒有一個**簡單直接的答案**。」

simple = 關係、原因或情況不複雜

12. **simple answer/solution (簡單答案 / 方案) — 直接；不複雜**

Practice 24

> “There is no **simple solution**.”

「沒有一個**簡單的解決方案**。」

Practice 25

> “The simple answer is no.”

「最**直接的答案**就是不。」

simple = 不需要很多條件、解釋或步驟就能表達 / 實現

13. **simple = single / not compound (單一的) — 單一；非複合**

A major technical/structural sense.

Practice 26

> “The device uses a **simple circuit**.”

「這個裝置使用一個**簡單 / 單一結構的電路**。」

Practice 27

> “The molecule has a relatively simple structure.”

「這個分子的結構相對****簡單****。」

****simple = 結構由較少部分組成，非多層 / 複合式****

14. ****simple sentence (簡單句) — 簡單句****

A major grammar term.

Practice 28

> “This is a ****simple sentence****.”

「這是一個****簡單句****。」

Practice 29

> “Begin with simple sentences before writing complex ones.”

「先寫****簡單句****，再寫複雜句。」

****simple sentence = 具有一個獨立分句核心、不是由多個獨立分句組成的句子****

This is a specialized grammatical sense.

15. ****simple interest (單利) — 單利****

A major financial term.

Practice 30

> “The loan uses ****simple interest****.”

「這筆貸款採用****單利****。」

Practice 31

> “Simple interest is calculated only on the original principal.”

「****單利****只按原本金額計算利息。」

****simple interest = 只按原始本金計算利息，而不把之前利息加入本金再計息****

This contrasts with:

> compound interest.

16. ****simple majority (簡單多數) — 過半數；簡單多數****

A common formal/political/organizational term.

Practice 32

> “The proposal passed by a ****simple majority****.”

「提案以****簡單多數 / 過半數****通過。」

Practice 33

> “A simple majority is enough to approve the motion.”

「只要取得****簡單多數****便足以通過動議。」

****simple majority = 支持票多於反對票 / 通常超過一半即可的多數形式，而非特別高門檻多數****

17. ****simple = pure / unmixed (單純的；純粹的) — 純粹；單純****

A more formal/technical branch.

Practice 34

> “The material is not a ****simple substance****.”

「這種材料不是一種****單純物質****。」

Practice 35

> “The reaction is not simple.”

「這個反應並不****單純****。」

****simple = 非混合、非複合，或不涉及多重成分****

This is lower priority than the everyday senses.

18. ****simply = in a simple way (簡單地) — 簡單地；以不複雜方式****

A major related adverb.

Practice 36

> “She explained it ****simply****.”

「她把事情****簡單清楚地****解釋了。」

Practice 37

> “The system is simply designed.”

「系統的設計很****簡單****。」

****simply = 以清楚、不複雜、容易理解的方式****

19. ****simply = merely / just (只是；只不過) — 只是；純粹****

A major separate adverb sense.

Practice 38

> “I was ****simply**** trying to help.”

「我****只是****想幫忙。」

Practice 39

> “There is simply no time.”

「****根本 / 實在****沒有時間。」

****simply = 只是 / 純粹；或用來加強某個直接、明確的說法****

This is genuinely different from:

> “explain simply.”

20. **simply because (只是因為) — 純粹因為；只是因為**

Practice 40

> “I like her **simply because** she is kind.”

「我喜歡她，**純粹因為**她很善良。」

Practice 41

> “You shouldn’t agree simply because everyone else does.”

「你不應該**只是因為**其他人都同意就跟著同意。」

simply because = 唯一 / 直接原因只是.....；沒有更複雜理由

21. **simply = absolutely / really (簡直；實在) — 簡直；完全**

An emphatic use.

Practice 42

> “That is **simply impossible**.”

「那**簡直不可能**。」

Practice 43

> “The view was simply beautiful.”

「景色**簡直美極了**。」

simply = 用來加強語氣，表示某種情況非常明確 / 強烈

22. **simplicity (簡單；簡潔) — 簡單性；簡潔**

A major related noun.

Practice 44

> “I like the **simplicity** of the design.”

「我喜歡這個設計的**簡潔**。」

Practice 45

> “The strength of the plan is its simplicity.”

「這個計劃的優點在於它的**簡單易行**。」

simplicity = 不複雜、清晰、容易理解 / 使用的性質

23. **simplicity = plainness / modesty (樸素) — 樸實 ; 簡樸**

Practice 46

> “She admired the **simplicity** of village life.”

「她欣賞鄉村生活的**簡樸**。」

Practice 47

> “The room was beautiful in its simplicity.”

「房間的美來自它的**簡約樸素**。」

simplicity = 不華麗、不奢侈、不複雜的風格 / 生活狀態

24. **simplify (簡化) — 使簡單 ; 簡化**

A major related verb.

Practice 48

> “We need to **simplify the process**.”

「我們需要**簡化流程**。」

Practice 49

> “She simplified the explanation.”

「她把解釋**簡化了**。」

****simplify = 減少複雜度、步驟或細節，使某物更容易理解 / 使用****

25. ****simplify language/instructions (簡化語言 / 指示) — 簡化****

Practice 50

> “Try to ****simplify the language****.”

「盡量****簡化語言****。」

Practice 51

> “The instructions were simplified for beginners.”

「指示已為初學者****簡化****。」

****simplify = 把原本較複雜的內容改得較清楚 / 容易處理****

26. ****simplification (簡化) — 簡化；簡化版本****

A useful noun.

Practice 52

> “The diagram is a ****simplification**** of the real system.”

「這幅圖是實際系統的****簡化版本****。」

Practice 53

> “Some simplification was necessary.”

「某程度的****簡化****是必要的。」

****simplification = 把複雜事物縮減 / 改成較容易理解形式的過程或結果****

27. **simplistic** (過度簡化的) — 把問題看得太簡單；過分簡化的

A crucial related adjective because learners often confuse it with **simple**.

Practice 54

> “That explanation is too **simplistic**.”

「那個解釋**過度簡化**了問題。」

Practice 55

> “It is simplistic to blame one person for everything.”

「把所有事情都怪在一個人身上，是一種**過分簡化的看法**。」

simplistic = 把本來複雜的問題過度簡化，以致忽略重要因素 / 細節

Usually negative.

28. **simple-minded** (思想簡單 / 單純；有時貶義) — 思想單純；頭腦簡單

A useful but delicate compound.

Practice 56

> “The character was portrayed as **simple-minded**.”

「這個角色被描寫成**思想單純 / 頭腦簡單**。」

Practice 57

> “Don’t assume a simple lifestyle means someone is simple-minded.”

「不要以為生活簡樸就代表一個人**頭腦簡單**。」

simple-minded = 思考方式非常單純，語境中可能帶貶義，暗示理解力 / 判斷較有限

Use carefully.

29. **simpleton** (傻瓜；較舊 / 貶義) — 頭腦簡單的人

A related lexical item, but lower priority.

Practice 58

> “He treated me like a **simpleton**.”

「他把我當成**傻瓜 / 頭腦簡單的人**。」

Practice 59

> “The word can sound insulting.”

「這個詞可能帶有侮辱性。」

simpleton = 被認為愚笨 / 頭腦過分簡單的人

This is dated/insulting enough that it should be recognized, not actively encouraged.

30. **simple** = not sophisticated / basic in taste or form (不精緻的) — 樸素 ; 簡單

A broader style/social sense.

Practice 60

> “They served a **simple meal**.”

「他們準備了一頓**簡單樸素的飯菜**。」

Practice 61

> “She prefers simple food.”

「她較喜歡**簡單樸實的食物**。」

simple = 沒有很多精緻加工、裝飾或複雜元素

31. **simple meal/food** (簡單飯菜) — 樸素 ; 不複雜

Practice 62

> “We had a **simple dinner** at home.”

「我們在家吃了一頓**簡單的晚餐**。」

Practice 63

> “The café serves simple homemade food.”

「咖啡店供應**簡單的家常食物**。」

****simple = 食物準備方式不複雜、不奢華****

32. ****simple = direct / without extra conditions (直接的) — 直接；單純****

Practice 64

> “The agreement is based on one ****simple rule****.”

「協議建基於一條**簡單直接的規則**。」

Practice 65

> “The principle is simple.”

「這個原則很**直接 / 簡單**。」

****simple = 不涉及額外條件、例外或多層結構****

33. ****plain and simple (就是這麼簡單 / 純粹如此) — 就是這樣；很直接****

A common fixed expression.

Practice 66

> “He was wrong, ****plain and simple****.”

「他就是錯了，**事情就這麼簡單**。」

Practice 67

> “We need more time, plain and simple.”

「我們就是需要更多時間，**沒有甚麼複雜原因**。」

****plain and simple = 強調事情非常直接明確，不需要額外解釋****

34. ****pure and simple (純粹就是) — 純粹；完全就是****

A related fixed expression.

Practice 68

> “It was greed, ****pure and simple****.”

「那****純粹就是****貪婪。」

Practice 69

> “The decision was unfair, pure and simple.”

「這個決定****根本就是****不公平。」

****pure and simple = 強調某事本質就是如此，沒有其他複雜成分****

Important distinction: ****simple vs easy****

This is one of the most important learner contrasts.

****simple****

= not complicated.

****easy****

= not difficult to do.

Something can be:

> ****simple but difficult****

For example:

> “The rule is simple, but following it is difficult.”

「規則很簡單，但做到並不容易。」

So:

****simple = complexity****

****easy = difficulty****

They overlap, but they are not identical.

Important distinction: **simple vs clear**

**simple**

= uncomplicated.

**clear**

= easy to understand because meaning is obvious/unambiguous.

A simple explanation is often clear, but not automatically.

> simple but unclear

is possible if the explanation is too vague.

Important distinction: **simple vs basic**

**simple**

= not complicated.

**basic**

= fundamental / elementary.

> simple explanation

= 不複雜的解釋

> basic explanation

= 基礎層次的解釋

They overlap but focus differs.

Important distinction: **simple vs plain**

simple

can mean:

- * uncomplicated;
- * plain;
- * easy.

plain

often means:

- * not decorated;
- * ordinary;
- * obvious/direct.

> simple dress

and:

> plain dress

can overlap, but **plain** often emphasizes lack of decoration more strongly.

Important distinction: **simple vs ordinary**

simple

= uncomplicated / plain.

ordinary

= not unusual or special.

A thing can be:

> simple but unusual

or:

> ordinary but complicated.

Different dimensions.

Important distinction: **simple vs small**

simple

= low complexity.

small

= low size/amount.

> a simple problem

= not complicated.

> a small problem

= limited in seriousness/scale.

Not interchangeable.

Important distinction: **simple vs short**

simple

= uncomplicated/easy to understand.

short

= limited length/duration.

A simple answer can be long.

A short answer can still be complicated.

Important distinction: **simple advice vs simplistic advice**

This is crucial.

simple advice

= clear and uncomplicated.

Usually positive/neutral.

simplistic advice

= oversimplified and ignores important complexity.

Usually negative.

Your passage means:

> **simple** 

not:

> **simplistic** 

Your grandmother's advice is straightforward, not intellectually shallow.

Important distinction: **simple vs naive**

simple

can be positive:

> clear and uncomplicated.

naive

= lacking experience/judgment, often unrealistically trusting.

Do not equate:

> simple advice

with:

> naive advice.

Important distinction: ****simple vs stupid****

These are completely different.

****simple****

normally means uncomplicated.

****stupid****

means lacking intelligence/judgment or extremely foolish.

Calling an explanation simple is usually positive.

Calling a person simple can sometimes be ambiguous or old-fashioned, so context matters.

Important distinction: ****simple person****

This expression can be risky because it may mean:

1. someone who prefers an uncomplicated/modest life;
2. in some contexts, someone seen as unsophisticated or intellectually limited.

For learners, avoid using:

> “He is simple.”

when you merely mean:

> “He likes a simple life.”

Be more specific.

Important distinction: ****simple life vs easy life****

****simple life****

= uncomplicated, modest lifestyle.

easy life

= life involving little difficulty/work.

A simple life may still involve hard work.

Important distinction: **simple design vs minimalist design**

simple design

= uncomplicated, few unnecessary elements.

minimalist design

= intentionally reduces elements according to a particular design philosophy.

A simple design is not necessarily minimalist.

Important distinction: **simple answer vs straightforward answer**

simple answer

= uncomplicated.

straightforward answer

= direct, clear, not evasive.

They often overlap, but **straightforward** emphasizes directness.

Important distinction: **simply = simply/easily vs merely**

Compare:

> “Explain it **simply**.”

= 用簡單方式解釋。

versus:

> “I’m **simply** asking a question.”

= 我**只是**問一個問題。

Same spelling, different adverb function.

Important distinction: **simply** = merely vs just

These often overlap.

> “I simply wanted to help.”

≈

> “I just wanted to help.”

Simply can sound slightly more emphatic/formal.

Important distinction: **simply impossible** vs merely impossible

simply impossible

= absolutely/clearly impossible.

merely impossible

is not normally equivalent and sounds odd in many contexts.

So the emphatic **simply** is its own important use.

Important distinction: **simplicity** vs simplification

simplicity

= state/quality of being simple.

simplification

= process/result of making something simpler.

> “I like the simplicity of the design.”

> “The diagram is a simplification.”

Different concepts.

Important distinction: **simplify vs shorten**

simplify

= reduce complexity.

shorten

= reduce length/duration.

You can simplify a document without making it much shorter, and shorten it without making it easier to understand.

Important distinction: **simplify vs summarize**

simplify

= make easier to understand.

summarize

= reduce to main points.

A summary is shorter; a simplification is easier.

They often overlap but are not the same operation.

Important distinction: **simple sentence vs short sentence**

simple sentence

= grammatical structure with one independent-clause core.

short sentence

= contains relatively few words.

A simple sentence can be long.

A short sentence can be grammatically complex.

Important distinction: **simple interest vs compound interest**

simple interest

= interest calculated only on original principal.

compound interest

= interest calculated on principal plus accumulated interest.

This is a genuinely specialized financial distinction.

Important distinction: **simple majority vs absolute/supermajority**

simple majority

= ordinary majority threshold.

supermajority

= higher threshold such as two-thirds.

absolute majority

can have a specific institutional meaning involving more than half of all eligible/total members rather than merely votes cast.

These should not be casually equated.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **simple** family is rich in complexity, difficulty, style, basicness, and simplification:

* **simple — easy to understand** = 簡單易明
 * **simple explanation/language** = 簡單清楚的解釋 / 語言
 * **simple — easy to do** = 容易完成
 * **simple task/process** = 簡單任務 / 流程
 * **simple — basic** = 基礎 / 初級
 * **simple structure/system** = 結構簡單
 * **simple — plain style** = 樸素 / 簡約
 * **simple design** = 簡潔設計
 * **simple life** = 簡樸生活
 * **simple pleasures** = 樸實小樂趣
 * **simple — uncomplicated situation** = 單純 / 不複雜
 * **simple answer/solution** = 簡單直接的答案 / 方案
 * **simple sentence** = 簡單句
 * **simple interest** = 單利
 * **simple majority** = 簡單多數
 * **simply — in a simple way** = 簡單地
 * **simply — merely** = 只是 / 純粹
 * **simply — emphatic** = 簡直 / 實在
 * **simplicity** = 簡單性 / 簡潔 / 樸素
 * **simplify** = 簡化
 * **simplification** = 簡化過程 / 簡化版本
 * **simplistic** = 過度簡化的
 * **simple-minded** = 思想單純 / 頭腦簡單 (有時貶義)
 * **simpleton** = 傻瓜 / 頭腦簡單的人 (較舊、貶義)
 * **plain and simple** = 就是如此 / 很直接
 * **pure and simple** = 純粹就是

The main semantic branches are:

- > **easy to understand**
- > **easy to do**
- > **basic / structurally uncomplicated**
- > **plain / modest**
- > **single / non-compound technical sense**
- > **simplification-related family meanings**

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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simple — easy to understand	內容或表達方式不複雜，因此容易理解
simple explanation/language	清楚、直接、沒有不必要複雜內容的表達
simple — easy to do	執行所需技巧、步驟或努力不多；容易完成
simple — basic	處於較基礎、初級、未複雜化的層次
simple structure/system	組成部分較少、結構不複雜
simple — plain style	外觀、設計或裝飾不繁複、不華麗
simple life	不奢華、不複雜、需求較少的生活方式
simple pleasures	不昂貴、不複雜但能帶來真實愉快的小事
simple — uncomplicated situation	關係、原因或條件較單純，不涉及很多層次
simple answer/solution	不需要很多條件、步驟或解釋即可表達 / 實現的答案 / 方案
simple sentence	只有一個主要獨立分句核心的句子
simple interest	只按原始本金計算、不把累積利息再計息的利息方式
simple majority	普通多數門檻，而非較高比例的特別多數
simply — manner	以清楚、不複雜、容易理解的方式
simply — merely	只是 / 純粹，表示事情沒有更複雜原因
simply — emphatic	用來加強語氣，表示某事非常明確 / 強烈；簡直
simplicity	不複雜、清晰、容易使用，或樸素簡約的性質
simplify	減少複雜度、步驟或細節，使某物更容易理解 / 使用
simplification	把複雜事物改成較簡單形式的過程或結果
simplistic	過度簡化複雜問題，以致忽略重要因素 / 細節
simple-minded	思考方式過分單純；某些語境可帶貶義
plain and simple	強調事情直接明確，不需要更多複雜解釋
pure and simple	強調某事本質完全就是如此，沒有其他成分

For your original passage

> “She listens first and then gives ****simple but thoughtful advice****.”

The exact meaning is:

****simple = clear, uncomplicated, and easy to understand****

Therefore:

> ****simple advice****

= ****「簡單、清楚、不複雜的建議」****

The word ****but**** is especially revealing:

> ****simple****

> but
> **thoughtful**

This rejects a possible misunderstanding.

The advice is:

> simple

but it is **not**:

> shallow
> careless
> childish
> simplistic

Instead, it is:

> easy to understand
>
> * carefully considered
> * meaningful.

So the best conceptual contrast is:

> **simple ≠ simplistic**

In your sentence:

> **simple advice**
> = 清楚直接、不複雜

whereas:

> **simplistic advice**
> = 把複雜問題看得過分簡單，忽略重要因素

The most important learner contrasts are:

> **simple explanation**
> = 簡單易明的解釋

> **simple task**
> = 容易完成的任務

> **simple design**

> = 簡潔 / 樸素設計

> ****simple life****

> = 簡樸生活

> ****simple solution****

> = 簡單直接的解決方案

> ****simple sentence****

> = 簡單句

> ****simple interest****

> = 單利

> ****simple majority****

> = 簡單多數

> ****explain it simply****

> = 簡單清楚地解釋

> ****I simply wanted to help****

> = 我只是想幫忙

> ****simply impossible****

> = 簡直不可能

> ****simplicity****

> = 簡潔 / 簡單性

> ****simplify the process****

> = 簡化流程

> ****simplification****

> = 簡化

> ****simplistic****

> = 過度簡化的

So ****simple**** is much richer than simply:

> ****simple = 簡單的****

and in your original passage it specifically means:

****“clear and uncomplicated, while still being thoughtful and meaningful.”****